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Culture (OWC): [Luguru \(FN32\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1965-1966

Coverage Date: 1965 AD - 1966 AD

Place Coverage

Uluguru Mountains, Morogoro Region, Tanzania

Section Title(S): Version 2

An unanswered question is why the spirit of Kingalu chose to go so far away and into the area of another, though related, people. It is also interesting that this people is referred to as the Zigua (Zigula, Seguha) whereas the place of the oracle is in the land of Nguru (Nguu, Ngulu), although all these peoples are related. Whatever the people the distance remains the same – about 80–100 miles as the crow flies – and not only is it far away, but the journey involves crossing the Uluguru range and walking across a huge plain to the Unguru area the other side, passing through bush which even today is full of wild animals. One might perhaps make a parallel with the Kula Ring and suggest that this important ritual contact provided the cloak for a trade link, since it is reported that there was iron-working nearby in the past (LAST 1883), and although there were smiths in the Uluguru area (there is a clan with the name of Waponda “smiths”) there is no tradition of iron smelting, and various clues point to the great importance of iron goods and their short supply¹⁵

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The conflict which is always a latent, indeed partially manifest, aspect of the relationship between brothers is illustrated by the insulting of Kingalu's nephew's wives by Sononga. We know that younger brothers call their elder brothers *sekuru* “grandfather”, and have to treat their wives with respect, whereas elder brothers have a joking relationship with their younger brothers' wives. If we recall the strong identification of a nephew with his maternal uncle, given added strength by the possibility of the former inheriting the latter's wives, then when Sononga insults the women of Suwapanga he is in effect doing the reverse of normal behavior, since these women are in some sense equivalent to the wives of his elder brother Kingalu. One might object that Sononga is also the maternal uncle of Suwapanga, but one finds in practice that there is usually a linking between a particular uncle and nephew rather than between all uncles and nephews. It is also clear that there is a further expression of the hostility towards affines since both Kingalu and Sononga must have married into the Sikoni clan, and whereas it seems that

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Kingalu and his nephew Suwapanga behave appropriately in allying themselves together to fight the Sikoni, Sononga allies himself with his affines.

When we come to the account of the war against Sononga we enter a phase filled with symbolic objects. In seeking the symbolism of these we may take ⁸³³ the standpoint adopted by MONICA WILSON and NADEL and only accept the interpretation offered by the informants, and reject "uncomprehended symbols" (NADEL 1954: 108). If we were to do this then we should be left solely with a pot, a knife, arrows, and so on, since informants were not explicit about any other meaning. I would prefer to accept TURNER'S endorsement of SAPIR'S position (TURNER 1967:29-30), and his own earlier suggestion of manifest, latent, and hidden aspects of symbols; latent meaning "the sense(s) of which the subject is only marginally aware but could become fully aware", and hidden sense(s) "of which the subject is completely unconscious and which is (are) related to infantile (and possibly pre-natal) experiences shared with most other members of his society" (TURNER 1962: 79). This viewpoint is clearly shared by MILNER (1969: 5-23). Another important point raised by TURNER is that of the "polysemy or multi-vocality" of symbols, so that "a symbol may stand for many things" (1967: 50). Until such time as we have an anthropologist who is a native of this area it will be hard for us to do more than speculate about the possible latent and hidden meanings of symbols, but it may be worth so speculating.

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¹⁵ There is a documented case of a group which long ago sold some of its land to another group for a hoe, and which in modern times tried to reclaim it for the same price. Another name for the "warden" is *Mwenye Shoka* "the axe holder".

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